The Many Faces of the Gospel

The gospel, once truly received, becomes visible in a transformed life, unstoppable in its spread, and certain in its future hope — leaving no room for a merely private, silent, or present-tense faith.

Where this study fits

1 Thessalonians · ten studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5
An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church

02 1:6–10
The Many Faces of the Gospel

03 2:1–12
Delivering the Gospel

04 2:13–20
A Successful Life of Service

05 3:1–13
Facing Tribulation

06 4:1–12
A Life That Pleases God

07 4:13–18
The Rapture of the Church

08 5:1–11
The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope

09 5:12–22
The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations

10 5:23–28
'Til We Meet Again

"Finally" (4:1) marks the hinge: chapters 1–3 lay the foundation; chapters 4–5 turn that theology into life.

Three faces of one gospel

1 Thessalonians 1:6–10 · Outline I–III

In person · 1:6–7

- They imitated Paul — and the Lord
- Received the word in much affliction
- With joy of the Holy Spirit
- Became an example to others

In proclamation · 1:8–9

- The word “sounded forth” — an echo
- Macedonia, Achaia, every place
- Turned to God from idols
- To serve the living and true God

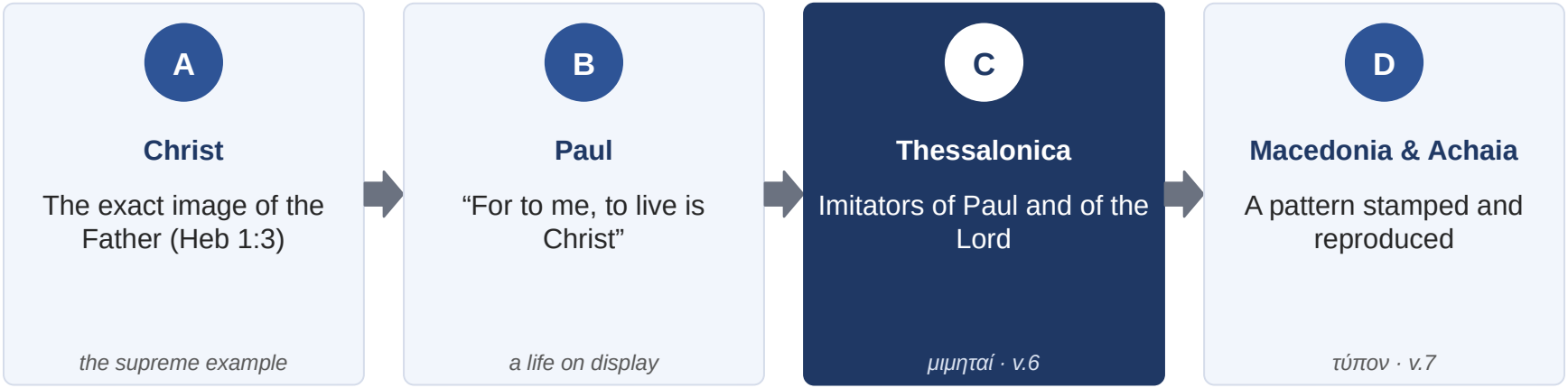
In prospect · 1:10

- Rapture — wait for His Son from heaven
- Resurrection — whom He raised
- Rescue — from the wrath to come

A life worth imitating, a testimony that echoes, a hope that waits. God does not wait for maturity before He produces something worth celebrating.

The chain of imitation

1 Thessalonians 1:6–7 · I.A–B — What they determined and demonstrated



“Imitate me, just as I imitate Christ”

- 1 Cor 11:1 — the chain always ends in Christ
- Paul was a signpost, never the destination

Discipleship is caught as much as taught

- Someone may be imitating you right now
- Would it draw them nearer to Christ?

Joy in much affliction

1 Thessalonians 1:6 · I.A.3–4 — Persecution eclipsed by joy

Happiness		Joy of the Holy Spirit χαρᾶς πνεύματος ἁγίου genitive of source
• Depends on what happens to you • Needs circumstances to cooperate • Cannot survive the climate of affliction	vs	• Rooted in God — the Spirit is its source • Fruit of the Spirit (Gal 5:22) • Grows inside affliction (θλίψει)

The test: “Was God glorified in this?” If yes — or if you know you were walking in obedience — you have the joy of the Holy Spirit, whatever it cost you.

The word sounded forth

1 Thessalonians 1:8–9a · II.A–B — The realm and reach of their witness

A

Thessalonica

On the Via Egnatia, with a busy harbor

a crossroads of the empire

B

Macedonia

Philippi, Amphipolis, Apollonia, Berea

the northern province

C

Achaia

Corinth and the south

Paul writes from Corinth

D

Every place

“We do not need to say anything”

v.8b–9a

ἐξήχηται has sounded forth — an echo still ringing (perfect tense)

An echo doesn’t need to be louder than the original sound to carry it further — only faithful to it.

“You turned to God from idols to serve”

1 Thessalonians 1:9b · II.C — The results of their witness

A common misreading

- Turning from idols was the condition for salvation
- Clean up first, then qualify for grace
- No one still wrestling with an idol could have assurance

vs

What the verse says ✓

ἐπεστρέψατε → δουλεύειν turned → to serve

- Turned to God — living and true
- From idols — what followed necessarily
- To serve — the fruit of salvation, not its price

They didn’t turn from idols to be saved. They turned from idols because they had been saved. Don’t confuse description with condition.

Rapture · Resurrection · Rescue

1 Thessalonians 1:10 · III.A–C — The gospel in prospect

Rapture · 10a
ἀναμένειν to wait for · G362

- “His Son from heaven”
- No sign attached (John 14:3)
- Present tense: a lifestyle of readiness

Resurrection · 10b
“whom He raised” from the dead

- Proof that the “living God” is living
- The hinge the whole hope swings on
- Not aspiration — inheritance

Rescue · 10c
ὀργῆς wrath · G3709

- “Who delivers us from the wrath to come”
- An earthly outpouring — the tribulation
- Removed before it, not through it

Christmas decorations in November tell you Thanksgiving is close — because Thanksgiving always comes first. Signs of the Second Coming tell us the Rapture is close.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 1:6–10 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Verse 9 says they “turned to God from idols to serve the living and true God.” Why does the order matter, and why is turning from idols not the condition for salvation?

2. The Thessalonians waited for Christ with no sign attached (1:10). How does a signless, any-moment hope change the way a believer lives day to day?

Apply

Become Someone Worth Imitating

Name one person who may be imitating you, and have one honest conversation about following Christ, not just you.

Live Ready, Not Anxious

Choose one responsibility you’d want to be found tending if Christ returned this week, and give it deliberate attention.

In one line: Live the gospel so it is worth imitating, speak it so it echoes past you, and wait for the Son who is coming.